



Hunting, Fishing & Trapping Field Manual

Survival hunting, fishing, and trapping across all US regions

\$20

Open-pollinated • Community-grown • Food sovereignty for everyone

Hunting, Fishing & Trapping Field Manual

Seedwarden | \$20

This guide is for people who want to understand how to get food from wild animals — not for sport, not for trophy, but for the table. That framing changes everything: shot placement matters because wasting meat is a failure; knowing where animals go in what conditions matters because an empty walk means an empty pot; understanding how to use every part matters because an animal's life is worth more than its backstrap.

This is also a survival guide in the practical sense. The methods here range from what you can do with a fishing line and a hook, to what you can do with a week of preparation and a proper rifle setup. Both are covered because situations vary and resources vary.

Know your local regulations. Hunting, fishing, and trapping are regulated at the federal, state, and in some cases local level. Seasons, bag limits, legal methods, required licenses, and legal equipment vary by state, species, and location. This guide covers techniques and principles; the legal framework in your specific area is your responsibility to know before you go out.

Important Notice

All hunting, fishing, and trapping in the United States is regulated by federal, state, and often local law. Seasons, methods, bag limits, licensing requirements, and legal equipment vary widely and change regularly. It is your responsibility to know and comply with every applicable regulation before you go into the field. This guide covers techniques and principles — it does not cover the legal requirements specific to your area. Treat every firearm, trap, and fishing setup as a safety matter first. If you are new to any of these activities, seek hands-on instruction from an experienced, licensed practitioner.

Part One: Tracking and Reading Sign

Before you hunt or trap, you have to know where animals are. Animals are not randomly distributed across a landscape — they move along corridors, concentrate near resources, and behave in predictable patterns shaped by food, water, cover, weather, and breeding. Reading sign is the skill that makes everything else possible.

Track Identification

How to read a track:

- Heel to toe: Which direction is travel? Fresh tracks have sharp, clean edges. Old tracks have eroded edges, frost crystals in winter, dried mud, or wind-blown debris in them.
- Gait pattern: Walk (two tracks side by side, regular spacing), trot (diagonal pairs), gallop (bounding — rear feet land ahead of front), lope. Each species has characteristic gait patterns.
- Substrate: Soft mud gives perfect impressions; dry dirt gives poor ones. Read the best track in any given set.

Whitetail deer: Heart-shaped cloven hoof; 2–3.5 inches long (doe) to 3–4+ inches (mature buck). Dewclaws (small oval impressions 1–2 inches behind the hoof) visible in soft substrate or snow when deer are running. Walking gait: rear foot lands in or near front foot track. Trailing a deer: keep looking ahead of the last confirmed track, not at it.

Mule deer: Similar to whitetail; slightly wider, more rounded cloven hoof; similar size.

Elk: Much larger cloven hoof, 3.5–5 inches; rounder than deer; massive compared to any deer track.

Wild turkey: Three long forward toes splayed wide; middle toe track 3–4 inches; overall track spread 4–5 inches. Dragging mark of the toe in soft substrate. Turkeys walk in single file along trails.

Rabbit (cottontail): Distinctive bounding pattern — two large elongated rear feet in front, two small front feet paired behind. Hind tracks 3–4 inches; front tracks 1 inch. Y-shaped track pattern when bounding.

Squirrel: Four-toed front, five-toed rear; small (1–1.5 inches); paired front feet, larger rear behind — similar bounding pattern to rabbit but much smaller.

Raccoon: Distinctive hand-like print; five toes on both front (1.5–2 inches) and rear (2.5–3.5 inches). Front and rear tracks often show together; walking gait.

Bear (black): Flat-footed; five toes; large round heel pad. Front track 4–6 inches wide; rear foot 6–9 inches long and looks remarkably similar to a human footprint. Claws show as small points above the toes.

Beaver: Rear webbed foot 5–6 inches; front 2.5–3 inches. Tail drag mark in mud or snow between tracks is distinctive.

Reading Sign Beyond Tracks

Deer rubs: A buck scrapes velvet from its antlers — and later marks territory — by rubbing against small trees (sapling to 3-inch diameter). Fresh rub: bright white wood, sap visible, strong pine/cedar scent. Rubs happen along travel corridors; a line of rubs indicates a regular travel route. Large rubs (3+ inch trees) indicate large, mature bucks.

Deer scrapes: A bare oval of dirt (12–36 inches) scratched by a buck's front hooves, often with a chewed or broken branch (licking branch) directly above it. Bucks urinate in scrapes during the rut. Active scrapes are

worked repeatedly — check for fresh track and urine smell. Scrapes are made along field edges, travel corridors, and pinch points.

Deer beds: Oval depressions in grass, leaves, or snow, approximately 2–3 feet long for a doe, 3–4 feet for a buck. Located in thick cover on south-facing slopes in cold weather (captures solar heat); in shade near water in summer heat. Multiple beds in an area indicate a regularly used bedding site.

Browse lines: A hard horizontal line in brush or forest understory at a consistent height (typically 4–5 feet for deer) where animals have eaten all available twigs and buds. Below the line is browsed; above is untouched. Indicates heavy deer pressure in an area.

Turkey sign: Scratching (leaves raked away in 1–2-foot circles, typically in groups) where turkeys have searched for food. Strut zones (open bare areas where a tom has dragged his wings while strutting — look for drag marks). Roosting trees (large open trees with clean sightlines; look for droppings and feathers accumulated beneath). Dusting areas (shallow bowl-shaped depressions in dry sandy soil where turkeys bathe in dust to control parasites).

Beaver dams and lodges: Look for gnawed stumps (conical, like a sharpened pencil) and drag trails through mud where beavers have moved branches to water. Active lodges have fresh mud plastered on the outside in fall.

Wind and Thermals

Wind is the single most important factor in hunting all animals with a strong sense of smell — deer, elk, bear, hogs. An animal that smells you will leave. There is no recovery from being winded.

The rule: Always approach animals, set stands, and still-hunt with the wind in your face or crosswind. Never downwind of where animals are or will be.

Thermals: In the absence of wind, air moves due to temperature differentials. In the morning, cool air sinks — thermals move downhill and toward water. In the afternoon, warming air rises — thermals move uphill. A ridge-top stand that is perfect in the morning (thermals carrying your scent away from bedding deer below) may be terrible in the afternoon (thermals now rising, carrying scent uphill toward bedding deer).

Check wind: Use a small bottle of unscented powder, a piece of thread tied to your bow or pack, or simply wet your finger and hold it up. Know which way air is moving before you move.

Part Two: Deer and Large Game

Whitetail Deer

The most widely distributed large game animal in North America. Found in every state except Alaska and Hawaii; in every habitat from northern boreal forest to subtropical Florida, from Appalachian ridges to Texas brush country.

Habitat and Daily Pattern

Whitetail deer are crepuscular — most active at dawn and dusk. A mature buck's typical day in fall:

- Pre-dawn to 1 hour after sunrise: Moving from feeding areas to bedding cover
- Mid-morning to mid-afternoon: Bedded in thick cover (south-facing slopes in cold; shade near water in heat)
- 1–2 hours before sunset: Rising, moving toward feeding areas
- Sunset through midnight: Active feeding; returning to bed

Food sources by season:

- Summer: Forbs, agricultural crops (soybeans, alfalfa), browse
- Fall pre-rut: Mast (acorns, beechnuts, hickory nuts) are the dominant food; any fall mast drop concentrates deer immediately beneath and around those trees
- Rut (November in most of the country): Bucks abandon normal patterns; pursue does at all hours; movement unpredictable but intense
- Late season/winter: Standing corn, cut agricultural fields, browse, cedar and pine (thermal cover)

The Rut

The peak rut (when the majority of does are in estrus) occurs within 2–3 days of November 13–17 across most of the country — driven by photoperiod (day length), not temperature. It can be felt earlier and end later, but the peak is remarkably consistent. South Texas ruts in December–January; extreme southern Florida ruts in summer.

Rut phases:

1. Pre-rut (October): Scraping and rubbing intensify; bucks begin seeking does
2. Seeking and chasing (late October–early November): Bucks actively running does; highly visible movement all hours
3. Peak rut (mid-November most regions): Does in estrus; bucks locked on individual does; sometimes stationary for 24–48 hours with a single doe
4. Post-rut (late November): Bucks exhausted and retreating; brief second rut in December when unbred does cycle again

Stand Placement and Approach

Key stand locations:

- Funnels and pinch points: any narrow passage in cover (a tree line between two fields, a saddle between two ridges, a creek crossing) concentrates deer movement
- Field edges: approach deer moving between feeding (fields) and bedding (woods) during crepuscular periods
- Mast trees with fresh dropping: a productive white oak dropping acorns will be hit hard immediately
- Scrape lines: a sequence of active scrapes along a trail edge is a reliable pre-rut location

Entry routes: Plan your approach to stand before you get there. Enter in darkness if needed, staying downwind of where deer will be — not where your stand is. Bumping a bedded deer out of its core area on the way to your stand defeats the purpose.

Tree stand heights: 15–25 feet reduces scent dispersal significantly. Higher than 25 feet has diminishing returns and increased fall risk.

Ground blinds: Set up and leave them in place 2–3 weeks before hunting to let deer habituate to them. Brush them in with local vegetation to break up the outline.

Shot Placement

The goal is to immediately destroy the heart/lung complex. A deer hit through both lungs dies within 50–150 yards in most cases.

Broadside (ideal): Aim directly behind the shoulder, one-third of the way up the body from the bottom of the chest. This places the shot through both lungs. On a deer standing perfectly broadside, the entry point is directly above the front leg.

Quartering away: Aim for the off-side shoulder. The bullet/arrow angles forward through the body cavity, destroying lung tissue. This is often a more ethically certain shot than broadside on moving terrain.

Quartering toward: More difficult; requires hitting the near shoulder and angling through to the vitals. Avoid this angle if possible.

Head and neck shots: Do not take these for field hunting. The margin for error is minimal; a slightly off shot produces a wounded deer with no blood trail.

Wait for the right shot. A deer at 15 yards with no ethical shot angle is worth more patience than the shot.

Field Dressing

Begin as soon as possible after recovery — bacteria multiply rapidly in a warm carcass, and heat retention in the body cavity accelerates spoilage.

Tools: Sharp fixed-blade knife (a 4-inch blade handles all field dressing), rubber gloves, a bag for organs you want to keep (liver, heart).

1. Position the deer on its back with the hind legs splayed. Prop in place on uneven ground or have a partner hold.
2. Starting just below the sternum (breastbone), make a shallow cut through the skin and abdominal wall, lifting the knife blade slightly upward to avoid puncturing the intestines. Extend this cut down toward the pelvis.
3. Optional: split the pelvic bone by cutting through the cartilage at the center of the pelvis with your knife or by using a bone saw. This makes removal of the colon easier.
4. Reach inside the chest cavity; find the esophagus and windpipe at the base of the throat; sever them as far forward as you can reach. Pull them back through the chest as you remove the organs.
5. Tip the carcass to one side; all viscera should roll out. Assist with your hands; pull the colon free from the pelvis.
6. Remove the bladder (located at the pelvic floor) carefully — do not puncture it.
7. Pull out the diaphragm (the thin membrane separating chest from abdomen) to access the heart and lungs.
8. Remove heart and liver; inspect liver — if spotted or showing lesions, discard it (liver flukes or other disease); otherwise it's excellent eating.
9. Prop the body cavity open with a stick to allow cooling.
10. Drag or pack out as quickly as possible; get the carcass hung and cooled.

Getting blood out: Use a garden hose or pour water through the cavity. Do not leave blood pooled in the cavity — it is a warm, wet environment for bacteria.

Target core temperature after field dressing: Below 40°F within 4 hours in cool weather; immediately iced if ambient temperature is above 50°F.

Quartering for Pack-Out

For backcountry kills more than ½ mile from a vehicle:

1. Skin the carcass completely before quartering — easier when the body is warm
2. Remove the two rear quarters at the hip socket
3. Remove the two front quarters at the shoulder (no socket joint — cut through connective tissue)
4. Debone the neck meat and rib meat (scrape off the ribs — this is significant meat often left behind)
5. Remove the two backstraps (along the spine on either side) and the two tenderloins (inside the body cavity along the spine)
6. Place each quarter and cut in a game bag (breathable mesh) to allow cooling while keeping out flies and debris

A whitetail doe in a good year yields approximately 50–60 lbs of boneless meat; a large mature buck 70–90 lbs.

Full Use of the Animal

- Backstraps (loins): The most prized cut; along both sides of the spine from shoulder to hip. Grill or pan-sear medium-rare.
- Tenderloins: Inside the body cavity; smaller but extremely tender. Cook the same day.
- Hindquarters: Round, sirloin tip, top round — excellent for roasts, jerky, or grinding
- Front quarters: More connective tissue; excellent for slow-cooking, braising, stew
- Neck meat: Excellent for grinding or slow-cooking
- Rib meat: Often wasted; scrape from ribs for grinding or stew
- Heart: Dense muscle; slice thin, soak in salted water, pan-sear or braise. One of the best cuts on the animal.
- Liver: Extremely nutritious; high in iron and vitamin A; best eaten fresh, sliced thin, pan-fried with onions. Freeze if not eating same day.
- Tongue: Braise low and slow; then peel the rough outer skin; slice thin. Delicate flavor.
- Bones: Split and simmer for bone marrow; or simmer whole carcass for rich stock
- Hide: Brain-tan or commercial tan; used for clothing, bags, moccasins, drum skins; sinew along the spine is one of the strongest natural cordage materials
- Sinew (back straps of connective tissue along the spine): Dried sinew is used for bowstring, thread, and binding; strip from the backstrap while the carcass is fresh
- Hooves and legs: Boil down for glue; the lower leg bones can be cracked and marrow extracted
- Antlers: Craft materials; knife handles; dog chews; calcium-rich ground for soil amendment; sheds (naturally dropped antlers) are found on the ground in late winter

Mule Deer and Elk

Mule deer occupy western mountains, high deserts, and sagebrush flats. They do not have the funnel-and-corridor movement pattern of whitetails; they tend to travel straight upslope to bed and straight downslope to feed. Glassing (using binoculars to spot animals from a distance before approaching) is the primary hunting technique in open western terrain.

Elk are herd animals; finding the herd and working them from downwind is the strategy. Elk are most active at dawn and dusk but can be found moving at all hours during the rut (mid-September to mid-October). Bull elk bugle during the rut — learning to call and replying with a bugle or cow call to locate and draw bulls is one of the most effective elk hunting techniques. Field dressing is the same process as deer, scaled up for a 500–900-lb animal. Quartering and pack-out from roadless country requires several trips or packhorses.

Black Bear

Black bears are opportunistic omnivores. They are most active in spring (emerging from dens, seeking early green-up) and fall (hyperphagia — extreme pre-denning feeding, often around mast crops or berry patches).

Baiting (where legal) is the most common hunting technique. **Spot-and-stalk** in open terrain; **hound hunting** (with dogs that chase and tree the bear) is traditional in many areas. Bears are heavily built and require well-placed shots — aim for the shoulder crease on a broadside bear to take out the shoulder and both lungs. Bears have a reputation for absorbing damage; double-lung shots are required for clean kills.

Field dressing is the same as deer. Bear fat is among the finest cooking and preservation fat available — render it like lard. Bear meat is edible throughout but requires **reaching 160°F internal temperature** due to trichinosis risk (same as pork).

Feral Hogs

Found across the Southeast, Texas, and increasingly the Midwest and California. Legal to hunt year-round in most states where they are present — they are considered an invasive pest species in most jurisdictions and have no closed season or bag limit in many areas.

Hogs are social animals that travel in groups called sounders. They are most active at night; dawn and dusk are most productive for daylight hunting. Hogs root heavily — look for ground that has been turned over as if by a rototiller. They wallow in mud (look for wallows near water). They travel the same routes repeatedly — ambush at these crossings.

Hogs are tough, with thick fat shields along the shoulder. Shot placement: aim directly behind the ear for a head shot, or for the shoulder crease for a body shot. A chest-cavity hit on a large hog may require an additional shot.

Field dressing same as deer. Hog meat is excellent; fat is renderable. Process quickly — hog carcasses deteriorate faster in hot southern weather.

Part Three: Waterfowl and Upland Birds

Ducks and Geese

Waterfowl migrate along four major flyways (Pacific, Central, Mississippi, Atlantic) from breeding grounds in Canada and the northern US to wintering grounds in the southern US and Central America. Migration timing varies by species and weather; major cold fronts push birds south.

Key locations: Marshes, flooded fields, river backwaters, large lakes with shallow areas, coastal bays and estuaries.

Decoys: A spread of 12–36 decoys creates the visual cues ducks use to identify safe landing areas. Mallard decoys work for most dabbling ducks. Set the spread with a landing zone (gap in the decoys) upwind of the blind — ducks and geese land into the wind.

Calling: Mallard hen calls (six-note greeting call, feed chuckle, hail call) are effective for dabbling ducks. Canada geese respond to standard honks and clucks. Over-calling drives wary birds away; call less as birds commit to the decoys.

Shooting: Waterfowl require steel or non-toxic shot (lead is prohibited for waterfowl federally). Pattern your shotgun with your chosen load — steel doesn't pattern the same as lead. Lead birds appropriately for crossing shots: maintain your swing after the trigger pull.

Cleaning ducks: Pluck or skin. Plucking preserves the fat layer (important for flavor and cooking); skinning is faster. To pluck: scald briefly or dry-pluck. To skin: make a cut along the breast and peel back; pull wings and legs through. Remove the oil gland at the base of the tail. Eviscerate through the rear vent. Save the liver and heart.

Wild Turkey

Wild turkeys are wary, have excellent vision, and are one of the most challenging upland game birds. A tom turkey in spring is arguably the most difficult legal game animal in North America to consistently kill.

Scouting

Find where turkeys roost (large trees with clean sightlines and horizontal branches; look for droppings and feathers below), where they strut (open areas, field edges, logging roads), and the travel routes between the two. Turkeys leave the roost at dawn, move to strut zones and feeding areas through mid-morning, loaf and dust in early afternoon, and return to the roost before sunset.

Spring Season (Most States)

The spring season targets toms (male turkeys) during the breeding season. A tom will come to the sound of a hen — this is the foundation of turkey calling.

Calling sequence:

1. Before legal shooting time: listen from a distance for toms gobbling on the roost; locate the roost
2. Move to within 100–200 yards of the roost before fly-down; set up against a large tree with your back covered (turkeys circle calls from a distance — you need to be visible from their direction of approach)
3. At first light, produce soft yelps and clucks as the tom is flying down
4. As the tom gobbles and approaches, call less — he is working toward you. Over-calling makes the hen seem to be approaching him, which is unnatural.
5. If the tom hangs up: stop calling entirely; silence sometimes draws a curious tom

Shot placement for turkey: Wait for the bird to be within 40 yards (most effective range for a shotgun with turkey loads). Aim for the base of the neck/top of the breast for a head/neck shot with a shotgun; this is the standard turkey shot. A rifle shot to the head or neck is effective in states where rifles are legal for turkey.

Upland Birds — Pheasant, Grouse, Quail

Pheasants inhabit agricultural areas with mix of crop fields and brushy cover. Hunt field edges, shelterbelts (rows of trees and shrubs), cattail marshes, and unharvested crop strips. A flushing dog is the most effective tool; walk slowly through cover and expect explosive flushes 20–30 feet in front of you.

Ruffed grouse are forest birds of the Northeast, Appalachians, Great Lakes, and Pacific Northwest. Found near alder thickets, aspens (drumming logs), and young second-growth forest. Solo walking with a close-working dog or hunting solo; they flush in short low bursts through timber.

Quail (bobwhite) are covey birds of the Southeast and Midwest found in broomstraw fields, pine savannahs, and brushy agricultural edges. Hunt with pointing dogs; coveys of 10–30 birds hold well for a point before flushing.

Part Four: Small Game

Rabbits (Cottontail)

The most accessible and widespread small game animal in North America. Cottontails are edge animals — they live where brush meets open ground. Fence rows, brushy creek bottoms, briar thickets, old orchards, and field edges are productive.

Best times: Dawn and dusk; also active on mild overcast days. After a snow, rabbits are visible against white ground and highly active.

Solo hunting: Walk slowly through brushy habitat; push through brush piles and briar tangles. Rabbits hold motionless when they see you, then bolt when you get very close. A slow, stop-and-go walking pace (pretending you see them, stopping unexpectedly) triggers earlier flushes.

With dogs (beagles): The traditional method. Beagles circle a jumped rabbit back to the hunter; rabbits run in circles when pursued. Wait where you jumped the rabbit.

Shot: 20-gauge or .410 shotgun with #6 shot; or .22 rifle.

Cleaning cottontail:

1. Hold the rabbit by the rear legs
2. Make a cut through the skin at the center of the back
3. Insert fingers into the cut and pull — skin peels off toward the head and rump in two motions
4. Remove the head and feet
5. Make a shallow cut along the belly; eviscerate
6. Check the liver — small white spots indicate Tularemia (*Francisella tularensis*); discard any rabbit with spotted liver and handle carefully (Tularemia is zoonotic)
7. Always cook rabbit to 160°F internal temperature — Tularemia is destroyed by heat

Rabbit parts: Entire animal is edible. Hindquarters are the meatiest; front quarters for stew. Pelt can be dried on a wire frame.

Squirrels

Squirrels are the quintessential survival small game — abundant, available in most habitats, harvestable with minimal equipment (a .22 rifle or even a sling), and edible.

Grey and fox squirrels are the primary species. Found in hardwood forest wherever there is mast production (oaks, hickory, beech, walnut). Listen in the morning for chattering and the sound of nut shells hitting the ground.

Hunting methods: Sit-still against a large tree and wait (squirrels return to normal activity within 15 minutes

of your stillness); or walk slowly and listen. The .22 LR is the ideal squirrel rifle — head shots are achievable at close range and waste minimal meat.

Cleaning: Same basic process as rabbit; squirrel skin is tighter and requires more effort to remove. Age squirrel in the refrigerator 1–2 days before cooking — it improves texture significantly.

Part Five: Freshwater Fishing — Lakes

Reading Lake Structure

Fish are not uniformly distributed in a lake. They concentrate at structural features:

Points: A finger of land jutting into the water creates adjacent drop-offs on both sides — bass, walleye, and pike use points as ambush locations.

Drop-offs and ledges: The transition from shallow to deep water; bass and walleye suspend along this edge. Fish the upper edge at dawn and dusk, deeper edges at midday.

Submerged timber and brush: Any structure that creates shade and current breaks; highly productive for largemouth bass, crappie, and catfish.

Weed lines: The outer edge of aquatic vegetation, where open water meets weeds; pike, bass, and perch hunt this edge.

Coves: Protected from wind; warmer water in spring (fish here when the rest of the lake is cold); cooler in summer.

Thermocline: In summer, lakes stratify — warm surface water above, cold deep water below, with a distinct temperature transition zone (thermocline). Game fish concentrate just above the thermocline where oxygen and temperature are optimal. Finding it with a fish finder or water thermometer tells you the productive depth.

Primary Species and Methods

Largemouth bass: Structure-oriented; associate with submerged timber, weed edges, dock shadows, and lily pads. Most active in water temperatures 60–75°F. Peak feeding at dawn and dusk; midday retreat to shade and depth. Natural baits: live nightcrawlers, large minnows. Lures: soft plastic worms, spinnerbaits, topwater at dawn.

Crappie and bluegill (panfish): School fish; find one and you've found the school. Crappie near submerged timber and brush in 8–20 feet of water; bluegill in shallower weedy areas and under docks. **Live minnows on a small hook with a bobber** is the most universally effective method. Also respond to small jigs (1/32–1/8

oz).

Catfish: Bottom feeders; active at night and in turbid, warm water. Set up with cut bait (fresh fish chunks), chicken liver, or commercial stink bait on a bottom rig near deep holes, channel edges, or below dams. Leave a bait soaking and wait.

Walleye: Open-water and bottom-hugging; most active at low-light periods (dawn, dusk, overcast days, night). Fish drop-offs and rock points. Live nightcrawlers on a bottom rig or spinner rig; jigs tipped with minnows or crawler.

Pike and muskie: Ambush predators; lurk near weed edges and submerged timber. Large lures (8–12 inch swimbaits, large spinnerbaits, topwater) or large live or dead bait fish. Steel leader required — their teeth sever monofilament.

Survival / Low-Tech Fishing Methods

Trotline: A main line (typically 100–400 feet of 100-lb test cord or rope) strung across a creek, channel, or along the bank, with drop lines (shorter lengths with a hook on each) every 2–3 feet. Set with cut bait, chicken liver, or nightcrawlers; check every 4–8 hours. Extremely effective for catfish, highly efficient in time and calories.

Limblines: Individual hooks and leaders tied to overhanging tree branches 12–18 inches above the water surface, with bait at the hook. The limb acts as a shock absorber and sets the hook as the fish runs. Set multiple lines along a bank and check periodically.

Fish traps / basket traps: A cone or funnel structure of wood slats, wire, or woven material that fish enter following bait but cannot easily exit. Effective for small fish; useful for consistent small protein source.

Hand lines: A length of line on a simple spool or wooden frame with a hook, sinker, and bait. No rod required. Drop into structure; feel for bites; hand-retrieve.

Spearing: In very clear, shallow water, fish can be spotted and speared. A sharpened wooden stake, a multi-pronged gig, or a trident works in shallow areas. Most effective for suckers, carp, and rough fish during spring spawning runs when they are in very shallow water.

Cleaning Fish

Scaling: Scrape from tail to head with the back of a knife or a spoon for fish that will be cooked whole or skin-on.

Filleting (most common for larger fish):

1. Make a cut just behind the pectoral (side) fin, angling toward the head, down to the backbone
2. Turn the knife and run it along the backbone from head to tail, keeping the blade as close to the bone as possible
3. Fold the fillet back and cut the skin away from the flesh (or leave skin-on)

4. Remove the rib bones by slipping the knife under them and cutting them free
5. Check for pin bones with your fingertip; remove with pliers or tweezers
6. Repeat on the other side

Pan-fish (bluegill, crappie): Scale, gut, and cook whole; or fillet with a flexible fillet knife.

Catfish: Have no scales but a tough, mucus-covered skin that must be removed. Grip through a cloth (slippery); use pliers to pull the skin away from a cut edge. Or skin with a rolling motion after making cuts around the body behind the fins.

Fish uses beyond meat: Fish roe (eggs) from most species are edible and can be pan-fried. Fish frames (spine, head, tail) make excellent stock — simmer 30 minutes, not more (fish stock becomes bitter with long cooking). Fish oil is rendered from fatty fish like salmon; use for cooking, skin care, or lamp fuel.

Part Six: Freshwater Fishing — Rivers and Streams

Reading Moving Water

Fish in rivers and streams avoid strong current when they can — they position at current seams where they can feed on drifting food without fighting the full force of the river.

Prime locations:

Pools: Deep, slow water below rapids or obstacles. Fish rest and feed here. The head of the pool (where fast water slows) and the tail (where it accelerates again) are the most productive zones.

Eddies: The calm water behind a rock or log in current. Often in a circular pattern; bait drifting into an eddy is trapped there, concentrating feeding fish.

Seams: The visible line where fast water meets slow — the foam line on the surface. This is where food concentrates and where fish station to intercept it.

Undercut banks: The bank on the outside of a river bend is undercut by current, creating an overhang where fish lie in ambush out of direct current. Wade along the inside of the bend and fish toward the undercut.

Riffles: Shallow, fast, rocky sections; less productive as holding water but excellent for feeding trout and smallmouth bass on aquatic insects.

Trout (Rivers and Streams)

Trout (rainbow, brown, brook) inhabit cold, clear, well-oxygenated water — generally rivers and streams above 65°F are too warm for trout. **Brown trout** are the most widespread and the wariest; **rainbow trout** are more aggressive; **brook trout** are found in the coldest, most pristine headwater streams.

Natural bait: Live nightcrawlers, minnows, crayfish tails, salmon eggs. Drift bait naturally through pools and seams on a light line with a small split-shot sinker.

Survival-scale method for streams: A simple hand line with a small hook, a split-shot sinker, and a nightcrawler drifted through a pool will catch trout in streams where they exist. Patience and minimal splash are required.

Best conditions for trout: Morning and evening; overcast days; water temperatures 50–65°F; early spring and fall; during insect hatches (watch for rising fish at the surface).

Improvised Traps and Primitive Methods

Rock weir: Build a rough dam of rocks across a shallow stream with a gap in the center, and position a cone-shaped fish trap or basket at the gap. Fish moving upstream are funneled into the trap.

Check dam and pool: Temporarily slow a small stream with rocks to create a deeper pool that concentrates fish for spearing or trapping.

Tickling (hand fishing / noodling): Locating catfish or carp sheltering under undercut banks or in holes; approaching slowly; allowing the fish to acclimate to your hand presence; grasping under the gill plate. Traditional and effective but requires practice and the right water and fish species. Catfish noodling is legal in many southeastern states.

Part Seven: Saltwater and Coastal

Surf Fishing

Reading the beach: Fish feed in turbulent water where bait is disoriented. Look for:

- Rip currents: The outward-flowing lane of disturbed water visible as a gap in the breaking waves; predators follow the channel
 - Troughs: Parallel depressions in the surf zone where water is deeper than surrounding sand — fish move through these
 - Points and jetties: Concentrate bait fish and predators; the turbulence at the tip of a jetty is always productive
-

- Sandbars: Fish the edge of the bar where it drops off into deeper water

Northeast surf: Striped bass (the signature surf species), bluefish, weakfish. Live or cut bunker (menhaden), sand eels, bloodworms. Best fishing at dawn, dusk, and night; moving tide (2 hours either side of high and low tide).

Southeast and Gulf surf: Red drum (redfish), pompano, flounder, sharks, whiting. Fresh shrimp, sand fleas (mole crabs), cut mullet, live finger mullet. High tide at dawn and dusk is most productive.

Pacific surf: Surfperch (most accessible), cabezon, striped bass (California), salmon near river mouths. Sand crabs (Pacific mole crabs), bloodworms, live bait.

Tides and Their Importance

Fish feed on moving tides, not slack water. The two hours before and after high tide are typically the most productive. At low tide, many inshore fish retreat to deeper channels. At high tide, they move into flooded flats, marsh grass, and structure that was previously dry.

Check tide charts (freely available online or via apps) for your area before fishing inshore.

Estuary and Inshore Fishing

Estuaries — where freshwater rivers meet the ocean — are among the most productive fishing environments on earth. The mixing of fresh and salt water produces a rich soup of plankton, baitfish, and crustaceans that supports nearly every species of inshore fish.

Flounder: Bottom-dwelling; lie flat waiting to ambush bait from above. Fish the bottom with a live minnow or a bucktail jig bounced slowly across sandy or muddy bottom.

Speckled trout (spotted seatrout): A schooling species of southeastern and Gulf Coast estuaries; find baitfish (look for birds diving) and they are nearby. Live shrimp under a popping cork is the traditional rig.

Red drum (redfish): Often found tailing (nose-down, tail above water) on shallow grass flats at high tide. Sight-casting with a live shrimp, crab, or gold spoon.

Mangrove snapper / gray snapper: Florida and Gulf Coast; around mangrove roots, docks, and structure. Live shrimp or cut fish; requires finesse — they are wary.

Shellfish

Clam digging: Softshell clams and hard clams (quahog) are found in intertidal mudflats. Look for the small holes and dimples they leave at the surface. Dig down 4–8 inches with a rake or by hand. Check local regulations — some areas require licenses; some are closed due to water quality.

Oyster harvesting: Oysters grow on hard substrate in estuaries; often visible as reefs at low tide. Use heavy gloves and an oyster knife; many states have minimal-equipment recreational harvest limits.

Blue crab trapping: Blue crabs are found throughout estuaries of the East and Gulf Coasts. A simple wire crab pot or a hand line with chicken necks tied at intervals (suspend over a dock or wade shallow grass flats) catches crabs effectively.

Red tide / Harmful Algal Blooms: Never harvest shellfish during or after a confirmed red tide or harmful algal bloom. Shellfish filter-feed and concentrate biotoxins (primarily saxitoxin) that are not destroyed by cooking and are dangerous at very low concentrations. Check state shellfish closure notices before harvesting.

Part Eight: Trapping

Trapping is regulated as strictly as hunting — check state regulations for required licenses, legal trap types, set requirements, and checking intervals. In a true survival situation, the following methods apply without the legal framework. In all other contexts, comply with state regulations.

Trap Types

Leg-hold (foothold) traps: A spring-loaded jaw that catches the foot or leg of the animal. Modern padded foothold traps cause minimal injury. Set at water's edge for mink, muskrat, beaver; on trails for fox, coyote, raccoon. Requires stabilizing with a drag or stake.

Body-grip (Conibear) traps: A square frame that closes on the body of an animal passing through it; designed for instant kill. #110 (small — for squirrel, mink, weasel), #160 (medium — muskrat, rabbit), #220 (large — beaver, otter, raccoon). Set at den entrances, in runs, or in water sets.

Cage traps: Wire cages with a trigger plate; capture animal alive. Less efficient than kill traps; useful for raccoon, rabbit, squirrel; allows release of non-target animals. Bait with corn, peanut butter, apple, or sardines.

Snares: Wire or paracord loops that catch an animal by the neck or body as it passes through. Simple, lightweight, packable. The most important primitive trapping tool for survival.

Snare Construction and Placement

Wire snares (most effective): Aircraft cable or 20–24 gauge snare wire; available at farm supply stores. Form a noose approximately:

- Rabbit: 4–5 inch diameter; set 4–5 inches off the ground at a natural chokepoint in a run
- Coyote/fox: 10–12 inch diameter; set at trail crossing

- Squirrel: 2–3 inch diameter; set on a pole leaning against a den tree or at a regular crossing

Snare placement for rabbit:

1. Find an active rabbit trail — look for tracks, droppings, and worn paths through brush
2. Set the snare at a natural narrowing in the trail (between two small trees, under a fallen log, through a fence)
3. Anchor the snare to a stake or heavy branch; the rabbit must not be able to drag the snare away
4. Height: bottom of loop should be 4–5 inches off the ground, sized to catch the neck

Paracord snare: Remove the inner strands from paracord; use the outer sheath to form a noose. Less effective than wire (animals can chew through) but packable and multi-use.

Improvised Deadfall Traps

Figure-4 deadfall: Three notched sticks supporting a heavy flat rock or log. The bait stick is notched into the others under the weight; when the bait is disturbed, the structure collapses. Requires practice to build reliably; works for small rodents and squirrels.

Paiute deadfall: A variation using a short toggle stick and a trigger string, allowing lighter trigger tension — more sensitive, better for smaller animals.

Placement: Deadfalls should be set where you observe active feeding or travel. Near burrow entrances, under trees with active squirrel activity, along visible runs.

Checking Traps

Check traps a minimum of every 24 hours — most states require every 24–36 hours by law. An unchecked trap that has caught an animal means a dead or injured animal sitting in the field. For survival-purpose trapping in a remote situation: check as frequently as practical, every morning at minimum.

Dispatching: A body-grip trap usually kills immediately. A foothold trap does not — dispatch quickly with a sharp blow to the base of the skull (for small animals), or a .22 shot. Keep the animal calm by covering its eyes before dispatch.

Part Nine: Equipment Lists

Minimum Survival Fishing Kit (Pocket/Pack)

This entire kit fits in a small tin or waterproof bag:

- 50 yards of 8–12 lb monofilament line
- Assorted hooks: #6, #8, #10 (small to medium; smaller hooks catch more fish)
- 6–10 split-shot sinkers (assorted sizes)
- 4–6 small bobbers / floats
- 2–3 small jigs (1/16 or 1/8 oz, assorted colors)
- 2 swivels
- 1 small needle-nose pliers / hook remover
- Snare wire (20 feet of 24-gauge aircraft cable)

Total weight: under 4 oz. Enough to fish any freshwater or inshore saltwater environment.

Day-Pack Hunting and Fishing Kit

Fishing:

- Ultralight spinning rod (5–6 foot, 2-piece collapsible)
- Small spinning reel with 6 lb monofilament
- Basic tackle box: expanded version of the survival kit above
- Fillet knife in sheath

Hunting (bow):

- Recurve or compound bow
- 6 arrows with broadheads
- Arm guard and finger tab or release
- Rangefinder
- Fixed-blade knife (4-inch blade) for field dressing
- Game bags (2–3 mesh bags)
- Rubber gloves

Universal:

- Headlamp with extra batteries
 - Fire-starting kit (lighter + ferro rod)
 - Water filter
 - First aid kit
 - Paracord (50 feet — doubles as snare material, game hang)
 - Folding saw (for quartering and bone work)
-

Full Camp Hunting / Fishing Setup

Fishing:

- Medium-heavy spinning or baitcasting rod (for larger species)
- 100-yard trotline with 24–36 drop lines and hooks
- Assorted natural bait containers (minnow bucket, worm container)
- Cooler with ice for fish transport
- Fillet gloves and flexible fillet knife
- Long-handled dipnet

Hunting:

- Centerfire rifle or shotgun (caliber/gauge by target species — see below)
- Quality optics (3–9×40 scope minimum for rifle)
- Ammunition (minimum 20 rounds of hunting loads)
- Tree stand or ground blind
- Scent control (rubber boots, scent-eliminating spray)
- Game cart or packframe for transporting carcasses
- Gambrel and rope for hanging/skinning
- Meat thermometer
- Vacuum sealer for field-processed meat

Trapping:

- 6–12 #110 body-grip traps (for small game)
- 4–6 foothold traps (for medium game)
- Trap stakes and anchor wire
- Snare wire (100 feet)
- Bait (corn, dried fish, commercial lure)

Caliber and Gauge Recommendations

Target	Recommended caliber/gauge
Small game (rabbit, squirrel)	.22 LR; .17 HMR; .410 or 20-gauge shotgun
Upland birds	12-gauge or 20-gauge shotgun
Waterfowl	12-gauge with steel shot
Wild turkey	12-gauge with turkey loads; .22 Mag or .
Deer (East, brush country)	.243, .308, .30-06, .30-30; 12-gauge slu
Deer (West, open country)	.270, .308, 6.5 Creedmoor, 7mm Rem Mag
Elk / moose	.308 minimum; .30-06, .300 Win Mag prefe
Bear, hog	.30-06 minimum; .300 Win Mag for bear
Survival / multi-purpose single firearm	12-gauge pump (handles everything from s

Bow (archery):

- Recurve: 40–55 lb draw weight minimum for deer; simpler, no mechanical parts to fail

- Compound: 50–70 lb draw weight; faster, flatter trajectory, more accurate at distance; requires more maintenance
- Crossbow: legal in all states for at least some seasons; easiest to learn; heavier than a traditional bow

Part Ten: Regional Summaries

Northeast (Maine, Vermont, New Hampshire, New York, Pennsylvania, New England)

Primary game: Whitetail deer (peak rut mid-November), black bear, wild turkey (excellent spring season), ruffed grouse, woodcock, snowshoe hare, cottontail

Primary fish: Brook trout (coldwater streams), brown trout, rainbow trout, largemouth and smallmouth bass, walleye, pike, perch, Atlantic salmon (Maine rivers), striped bass (coastal)

Key seasons: Deer firearms November; turkey spring April–May; grouse September–November; ice fishing January–March

Habitat: Mixed hardwood-conifer forest, agricultural valleys, rocky ridges; extensive state and national forest public land

Notes: Deep snow limits deer movement in January–February; deer concentrate in thermal cover (softwood stands). Trout in the Adirondacks and northern New England are among the best in the country. Striped bass run the coast in May–October.

Southeast (Virginia, Carolinas, Georgia, Alabama, Mississippi, Tennessee, Kentucky)

Primary game: Whitetail deer (peak rut late November–early December in the north; December–January in the deep South), wild turkey (excellent), black bear (Appalachians), feral hog (increasingly widespread)

Primary fish: Largemouth bass (exceptional), catfish, crappie, striped bass (reservoirs), mountain brook trout (southern Appalachians), redfish and flounder (coast)

Key seasons: Deer opens early September in some states; long bow seasons; turkey spring March–May

Habitat: Hardwood forests, pine plantations, agricultural bottomlands, coastal marshes

Notes: Extended deer seasons (August–January in some states); hot humid summers limit summer hunting activity. Spanish moss hanging from live oaks often marks productive turkey habitat.

Midwest — Great Lakes (Ohio, Indiana, Illinois, Michigan, Wisconsin, Minnesota)

Primary game: Whitetail deer (peak rut November 7–14), wild turkey, pheasant (Illinois/Indiana agricultural areas), ruffed grouse (Great Lakes states), black bear (Minnesota/Wisconsin/Michigan Upper Peninsula)

Primary fish: Walleye (the region's most prized fish; Lake Erie is the walleye capital of North America), largemouth and smallmouth bass, muskellunge, pike, perch, lake trout (Great Lakes)

Key seasons: Deer firearms mid-November through December; turkey April–May; walleye open water May–October; ice fishing December–March

Habitat: Agricultural fields and woodlots in the south; mixed hardwood-conifer forest north; Great Lakes shoreline

Notes: Great Lakes provide significant commercial and sport fishing opportunity; tributary trout and salmon runs in fall. Peak rut timing is very consistent in this region — mid-November is the most reliable hunting window in the country.

Great Plains (North Dakota, South Dakota, Nebraska, Kansas, Iowa, Missouri)

Primary game: Whitetail deer (eastern portion), mule deer (western portion), pronghorn (western Nebraska, SD), pheasant (exceptional — the region is the center of North American pheasant hunting), wild turkey

Primary fish: Catfish (Missouri River system), walleye, bass, crappie, paddlefish (Missouri River)

Key seasons: Pheasant opens November 1 in most states; deer firearms October–December; pronghorn September; turkey spring

Habitat: Tallgrass and shortgrass prairie, agricultural fields, river corridors with timber

Notes: Pheasant hunting in South Dakota and Kansas is some of the best in North America. River corridor deer are often overlooked and hold large populations. Pronghorn antelope require long-range shooting skills (common shots at 300+ yards in open prairie).

Southwest (Texas, New Mexico, Arizona, Oklahoma)

Primary game: Whitetail deer (Texas Hill Country — exceptional), mule deer (western Texas/NM/AZ), pronghorn (NM/AZ), javelina (TX/AZ/NM), feral hog (Texas — year-round, no bag limit), elk (NM/AZ), turkey (Rio Grande subspecies)

Primary fish: Largemouth bass (Texas reservoirs — trophy fish), catfish, striped bass (Texas reservoirs), redfish (Gulf Coast), flounder, specked trout (Texas coast)

Key seasons: Texas deer opens November; hog hunting year-round; Gulf Coast fishing year-round

Habitat: Hill country cedar/live oak, desert shrub, canyon country, irrigated agricultural areas, Gulf Coast marshes

Notes: Texas has more private land and more deer than any other state; access arrangements (leasing) are

important. Texas Gulf Coast is one of the finest inshore fisheries in North America — redfish, speckled trout, and flounder available year-round. Feral hog hunting in Texas requires no license for non-residents on private land.

Rocky Mountains (Colorado, Wyoming, Montana, Idaho, Utah)

Primary game: Elk (the signature species), mule deer, pronghorn (WY/MT/ID), black bear, mountain goat (limited draw tags), bighorn sheep (limited draw tags), pheasant and Hungarian partridge in agricultural valleys

Primary fish: Cutthroat trout (native; excellent in high mountain streams), rainbow and brown trout, mountain whitefish, lake trout (larger reservoirs and lakes)

Key seasons: Elk archery September (rut); rifle October–November; deer combined seasons. Trout fishing open most of year with seasonal restrictions.

Habitat: Alpine and sub-alpine forest, sagebrush foothills, river valleys, wilderness areas

Notes: Public land access is extensive — millions of acres of national forest and BLM land. Elk hunting in September during the rut (calling bulls) is among the most exciting and physically demanding hunting in North America. High altitude (8,000–11,000 ft) requires physical conditioning. Pack-out from backcountry elk requires planning — a bull elk can weigh 700+ lbs.

Pacific Northwest (Washington, Oregon)

Primary game: Black-tailed deer (subspecies of mule deer; coastal forest), Roosevelt elk (the largest elk subspecies; coast range and Cascades), black bear, cougar (limited seasons), upland birds (forest grouse, pheasant in agricultural areas)

Primary fish: Chinook and coho salmon (exceptional; both tidal rivers and open coast), steelhead trout (winter and summer runs), Pacific halibut, bottomfish (lingcod, rockfish), Dungeness crab

Key seasons: Deer and elk October–November; salmon runs July–December depending on species and river; crabbing year-round with seasonal peaks

Habitat: Dense temperate rainforest, coast range, Columbia Plateau (eastern WA/OR); extensive public land

Notes: Black-tailed deer are extremely difficult to hunt in dense coastal timber — local scouting and still-hunting skills are essential. Pacific salmon runs are world-class; the Columbia River system supports significant steelhead fishing. Dungeness crab trapping in coastal bays produces excellent eating.

Alaska

Primary game: Moose (the primary big game; 800–1,500 lbs; accessible by river), caribou (migratory herds), Sitka black-tailed deer (Southeast AK), brown/grizzly bear (predator), black bear, Dall sheep (mountain), mountain goat

Primary fish: All five Pacific salmon species (king/Chinook, sockeye, coho, pink, chum), rainbow trout, arctic grayling, lake trout, Dolly Varden, halibut, Pacific cod

Key seasons: Moose September–October; caribou August–September; salmon runs June–September depending on species and drainage

Habitat: Boreal forest, tundra, river systems, alpine zones, coastal wetlands

Notes: Alaska is the most game-abundant landscape in North America. A moose provides 400–700 lbs of meat — adequate protein for one person for a year. Most productive hunting and fishing accessible by boat or floatplane. The Alaska residents' subsistence hunting and fishing system is one of the most important food-production frameworks in the state; understanding it is important for anyone in rural Alaska.

Gulf Coast (Louisiana, Florida, Mississippi coastal areas)

Primary game: White-tailed deer (unique lowland subspecies; peak rut late December–January in south Florida; November in northern Gulf Coast states), wild turkey, feral hog (year-round)

Primary fish: Redfish, speckled trout, flounder (inshore trifecta), tarpon (summer; catch-and-release only in most areas), snook (Florida), mangrove snapper, largemouth bass (inland), catfish

Key seasons: Deer October–January; turkey spring March–April; saltwater fishing year-round (best October–May for inshore species)

Habitat: Coastal marshes, cypress swamps, palmetto flatwoods, mangrove estuaries (south Florida)

Notes: Gulf Coast inshore fishing is among the most productive in the country — the shallow estuaries and grass flats support enormous populations of redfish and speckled trout. Alligator hunting (with proper permits) is unique to this region; gar, bowfin, and other rough fish are present in large numbers in freshwater systems.

Part Eleven: Safety and Survival Considerations

Never hunt alone without telling someone your location and expected return time.

Blaze orange: In most states, blaze orange (a minimum of 400 square inches) is required during firearm deer seasons. It saves lives.

Tree stand falls kill more hunters annually than shooting accidents. Use a full-body harness whenever you are off the ground; attach your harness to the tree before you leave the ground.

Know what's behind your target before you shoot. Every bullet or arrow that misses or passes through must land somewhere.

Hypothermia kills hunters who get wet in cold conditions, particularly if they've sweated during the day and then stopped moving. Carry a change of insulating layers in your pack.

Tularemia (rabbit fever): Always wear rubber gloves when cleaning rabbits and squirrels; cook all small game to 160°F. The bacteria is destroyed by heat but is highly infectious through cuts and mucous membranes during field dressing.

Chronic Wasting Disease (CWD): A prion disease of deer and elk present in many parts of the country. Do not consume brain, spinal cord, eyes, spleen, or lymph nodes of deer in CWD-affected areas. Bone-in meat from CWD-positive deer should not be consumed. Check your state wildlife agency for CWD zones before consuming harvested deer.

Related Seedwarden guides:

- Meat, Fish & Animal Products Preservation Field Manual — how to preserve everything you harvest
- Harvest Preservation Field Manual — root cellaring, drying, canning for plant foods
- Survival Garden Regional Plans — what to grow alongside what you hunt and fish

More from Seedwarden

If you found this guide useful, you might also like:

- Meat, Fish & Animal Products Preservation Field Manual (\$18) — Preserve every catch and harvest with smoking, curing, and salt techniques
- Small-Scale Livestock Field Manual (\$18) — Raise chickens, rabbits, and goats to complement wild-harvested protein
- Survival Garden Regional Plans (\$18) — Grow calorie-dense crops alongside what you hunt, fish, and trap

Browse all Seedwarden guides at [\[our Etsy shop\]](#).